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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Pension dispute ensnares staffers

Beneficiaries sometimes take back seat in Chicago's \$175M political tug-of-war

By Nell Salzman, A.D. Quig and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Tiwanida Parker, a college and career coach at Marshall High School, wonders how she could make a convincing argument for students to apply for jobs at Chicago Public Schools without a more stable pension picture.

"We have to make sure that we believe in this profession," she said. "And a part of believing in this profession is ... making sure that those basic benefits are in place."

Who picks up the bill for the disputed \$175 million pension payment for nonteaching CPS staff has been a question mark for the district in recent months. It is part of what led to the resignation of the previous school board and the subsequent firing of schools chief Pedro Martinez late last year. Fast forward three months, and the ongoing back-and-forth is part of what led to last week's delay of a budget amendment to balance the city's books by the end of March.

The city has made the payment to the Municipal Employees' Annuity and Benefit Fund but is awaiting reimbursement from CPS. Mayor Brandon Johnson and predecessor Lori Lightfoot have argued CPS should be responsible, while Martinez repeatedly has said the payment is the city's legal obligation. The district said in a statement to the Tribune it doesn't have the money to cover the pension payment on top of the costs of a new teachers contract.

"Chicago Public Schools officials have been clear for more than a year that CPS, like many districts, is facing a challenging fiscal situation without federal

Turn to Pension, Page 5

Tribune lawsuit against OpenAI and Microsoft will proceed

By Josephine Stratman
New York Daily News

NEW YORK — A federal judge rejected a majority of motions by OpenAI and Microsoft to dismiss parts of a lawsuit accusing the tech companies of swiping stories from the Chicago Tribune, The New York Times and other newspapers to train their AI products.

The Tribune, its affiliated newspapers in MediaNews Group and Tribune Publishing, the Times and the Center for Investigative Reporting have accused OpenAI and Microsoft of stealing millions of copyrighted news stories to benefit popular AI products like ChatGPT.

Manhattan federal Judge Sidney Stein's ruling Wednesday preserves the core elements of the lawsuit, which will now go forward to trial. While Stein rejected efforts to dismiss claims related to statute of limitations, trademark dilution and stripping content management information (CMI) from the content in question, he dismissed CMI claims against Microsoft along with a secondary CMI claim against OpenAI, and one other unfair competition claim against both defendants. The judge dismissed

Turn to OpenAI, Page 2

All is not frost

A dry and mild start to Chicagoland's winter led to below-average ice cover on Lake Michigan, along with a big drop in water levels

By Adriana Pérez | Chicago Tribune

Chicago-area residents might feel like it's been a really long winter after enduring stretches of below-normal temperatures in January and February and a couple snowfalls in March. But the lingering cold snaps actually contributed to a proper winter — unlike the record highs and bitter but brief Arctic blasts of recent years. "You look at the numbers — whether it be for Chicago, for Illinois, for the Great Lakes — and it was sort of an unremarkable winter," said Trent Ford, the Illinois state climatologist. "But it felt like it was intense because we're getting these types of winters, as far as temperatures are concerned, so much less frequently. "At one point in late February, I was like: My god, it's been cold forever. I'm so tired of this," he said.

Last winter, atmospheric temperatures in the area averaged 34.9 degrees, which was 6.8 degrees above normal, according to the National Weather Service. February 2024 was the warmest in Chicago and Illinois in nearly 150 years, and overall it was the city's fifth warmest winter on record. It tracked with last year being the hottest year on record globally, with 15 straight months of record-breaking temperatures from June 2023 through August 2024, according to NASA. But the cold, seemingly normal winter this

People walk in the snow near the limestone rocks at Promontory Point next to an ice-free Lake Michigan on Jan. 14. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

year doesn't disprove longer-term warming trends from human activity and heat-trapping greenhouse gases. In fact, despite the persistent winter temperatures, ice cover on Lake Michigan and snowfall in Illinois were below average likely due to an abnormally warm, dry beginning to the season. Ice cover on four of the Great Lakes remained mostly below long-term averages. Ford said the core, coldest months of the

Turn to Winter, Page 5

A man whose 'Perspective' changed TV

After more than 50 years on air, Jacobson to hang up mic

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

For more than half a century, legendary Chicago news anchor and commentator Walter Jacobson has been broadcasting his views on everything from the city's colorful politicians to the Cubs, for whom he once worked as a batboy.

On Thursday morning, he will deliver one last "Perspective" on WGN Radio, home to his weekly commentary segment for the past decade, and perhaps conclude the final chapter of a storied Chicago broadcast career.

"Commentary was always the most important thing for me, by far," said Jacobson, 87. "I've always been interested in government and politics, and when I had the freedom to say what I wanted to say was right or wrong, that was a blessing for me."

The two-minute radio segment will mark the end of a prodigious run for Jacobson, who once disrupted the airwaves as the unlikeliest of TV news anchors.



Joe Romano, right, technical director for the "Bob Sirott Show," shakes hands with commentator Walter Jacobson on Wednesday at WGN Radio, where Jacobson will deliver one last "Perspective" on Thursday morning. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

When Jacobson was paired with co-anchor Bill Kurtis at WBBM-Ch. 2 from 1973 to 1982, his signature commentary segment was an integral part of the station's top-rated 10 p.m. newscast. Seated at a separate cluttered desk, often wearing suspenders and glasses later revealed to be purely cosmetic, he gave a feisty take on the day's biggest story, setting the CBS-owned station and Jacobson apart from the happy-talk newscasts that had predominated. The unusual combination of Kurtis, the

quintessential anchorman, and Jacobson, a scrappy muckraker, became the yin and yang of local TV news, forming one of the most iconic teams in Chicago broadcast history.

"I was never a great anchorperson — I haven't got the voice," Jacobson said. "Bill was always the strength; I was the awkward guy and troublemaker."

Kurtis called it a "forced marriage" that

Turn to Jacobson, Page 4

'She was a remarkable person'

A family begins to feel closure after a car that belonged to a 23-year-old Elgin woman missing since 1983 was pulled from the Fox River on Tuesday. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

Ballpark shooting still a mystery

How were two women shot while sitting in the bleachers at a White Sox game in August 2023? Nineteen months have passed and there's little clarity. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Dems vow to defend election law

Democrats in Springfield are promising to protect Illinois election laws against a sweeping executive order from the Trump administration Tuesday. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

